TOPIC 1 · WHAT DIGITAL EVIDENCE IS

5 minutes · records that show what happened · minimum evidence by incident type · leads and proof

What is it?

Digital evidence is any record that helps establish what happened: chats, call logs, bank messages and statements, emails, web addresses (URLs), profile IDs, app details, photos of a screen, and device information.

Collect the **minimum** evidence the agencies need to act — enough to identify the transaction, the account and the suspect identifiers — without delaying help. Safety and live loss always come before evidence capture.



Figure 5.3 · What to save, by incident type

Identifier	Why it matters	Where to find it
UTR / transaction ID	Lets banks trace and hold money	UPI app → history → transaction details; bank SMS
Suspect phone number and UPI ID	Lets telecom and payment providers act	Call log; chat header; payment screen
Profile URL or user ID	Display names change; IDs do not	Profile → share → copy link
Website address (full URL)	Allows take-down and tracing	Browser address bar; long-press link → copy
Email headers	Show the real sending server	Email app → “Show original” or “View source”

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TOPIC 2 · NATIVE RECORD AND WORKING COPY

5 minutes · keep originals untouched · complete screenshots · chat export · statements · common mistakes

What is it?

The **native record** is the original item where it lives — the chat inside WhatsApp, the email in the mailbox, the transaction in the bank's system. A **working copy** is a screenshot, export or download made from it. Copies are useful, but the original must stay untouched so that the police can collect it properly later.



Figure 5.4 · Native record and working copy

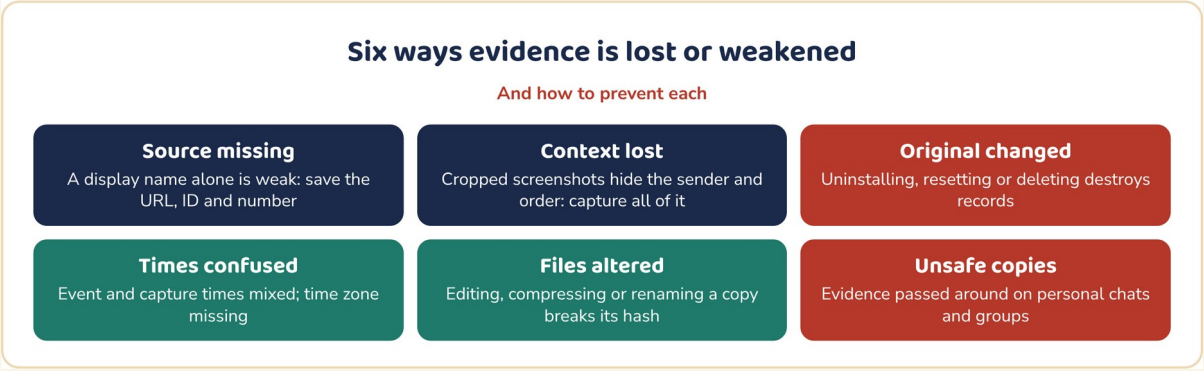


Figure 5.5 · Six ways evidence is lost or weakened

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Good capture	How	Poor capture
Full screenshot	Shows the sender's number or profile, the date and the full message thread, with the phone's status bar	Cropped image of one message
Scrolling sequence	Several screenshots in order, numbered E-01a, E-01b…	Random screenshots with gaps
Chat export	Chat → More → Export chat (with media if needed); keeps the original in the app	Forwarding messages to yourself
Bank statement	Official PDF statement or transaction detail from the bank app	Photo of the bank SMS only
Web page	Screenshot showing the full address bar plus the URL copied as text	Screenshot without the address

Ask yourself

- Does every screenshot show who sent it, when, and the full context?
- Is the original still on the citizen's device or account?
- Have I avoided moving evidence through personal chats or groups?

Stop	Save	Report
Ask the citizen not to delete, reset or uninstall anything.	Capture full screenshots and exports as working copies; save the master once.	Hand copies to the agency through its portal or in person, with a receipt.

Remember

Copies help; the original still matters. Never delete the original, even after screenshots.

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TOPIC 3 · TIME, TIME ZONES AND METADATA

5 minutes · event time · capture time · transfer time · IST · what metadata is

What is it?

Every item has at least three times: when it **happened**, when it was **captured**, and when it was **transferred**. Confusing them is one of the commonest reasons complaints are delayed. Always write the date, the time and "IST".

Metadata is "data about data": when a file was created, by which device, sometimes where. Social media and messaging apps often strip or change metadata, which is another reason to keep the native record and to note times yourself.

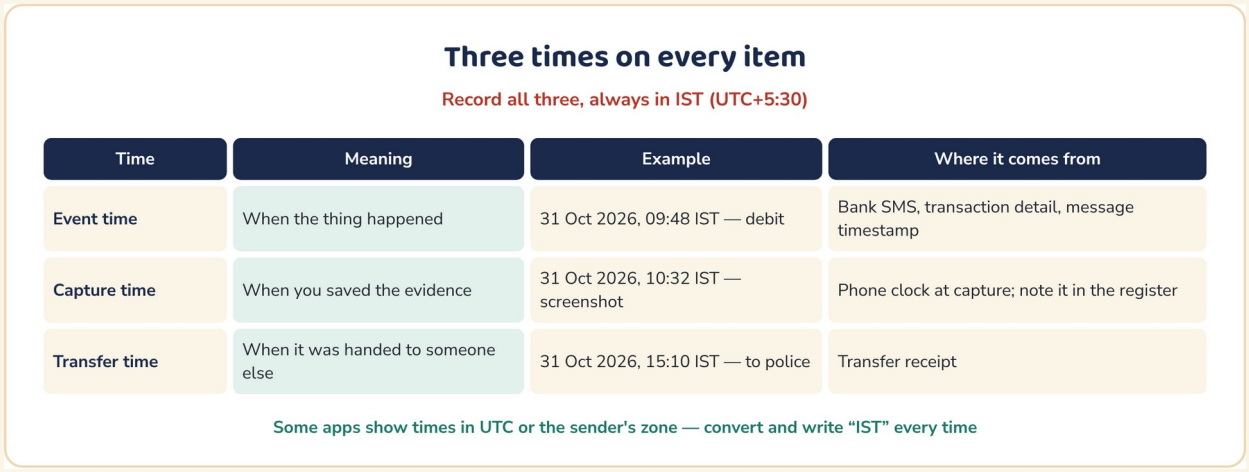


Figure 5.6 · Three times on every item

Situation	What to do
App or email shows time in UTC (GMT)	Add 5 hours 30 minutes and write IST; note "converted from UTC"
Citizen's phone clock is wrong	Note the difference against a reliable clock at capture time
Citizen is unsure when it happened	Record "approx." and the reason; never invent a precise time
Several transactions	One register row per transaction, each with its own UTR and time

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TOPIC 4 · EVIDENCE REGISTER AND CHAIN OF CUSTODY

5 minutes · register fields · item IDs · storage · transfer receipts · acknowledgement

What is it?

The **evidence register** is a simple table with one row per item. The **chain of custody** is the record of every person who has held the item, when and why. Together they let anyone check that the evidence is complete and has not been tampered with.



Figure 5.7 · The chain of custody

EXAMPLE REGISTER (TRAINING CASE M5-008)

Item	Description and source	Event time	Capture time	Method	Storage / hash
E-01	WhatsApp chat with +91 9XXXX XX201 (suspect), citizen's phone	30 Oct 18:20 IST	31 Oct 10:32 IST	Chat export + 4 screenshots	Folder M5-008 · SHA-256 9f2c…03f5
E-02	Bank SMS: debit ₹18,400, UTR 4301XXXX7781	31 Oct 09:48 IST	31 Oct 10:35 IST	Screenshot	Folder M5-008 · SHA-256 1a7d…88c2
E-03	Bank statement PDF, 30–31 Oct	—	31 Oct 11:02 IST	Download from bank app	Folder M5-008 · SHA-256 c3e9…5b10

Transfer receipt field	Example
Items	E-01 to E-03 (working copies) with hashes listed
From / to	Responder R. Patil → Cyber Police Station, Constable S. Khan
Date and time	31 Oct 2026, 15:10 IST
Purpose	Attachment to complaint; NCRP acknowledgement noted
Signatures	Giver and receiver; copy kept in case file

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TOPIC 5 · INTEGRITY HASHING WITH SHA-256

5 minutes · what a hash is · computing SHA-256 · comparing hashes · what a hash proves

What is it?

A **hash** is a fixed-length "fingerprint" calculated from a file. **SHA-256** is a widely used hash method. If even one dot of the file changes, the hash changes completely. Recording the hash of the master copy lets anyone later show that a working copy is identical.

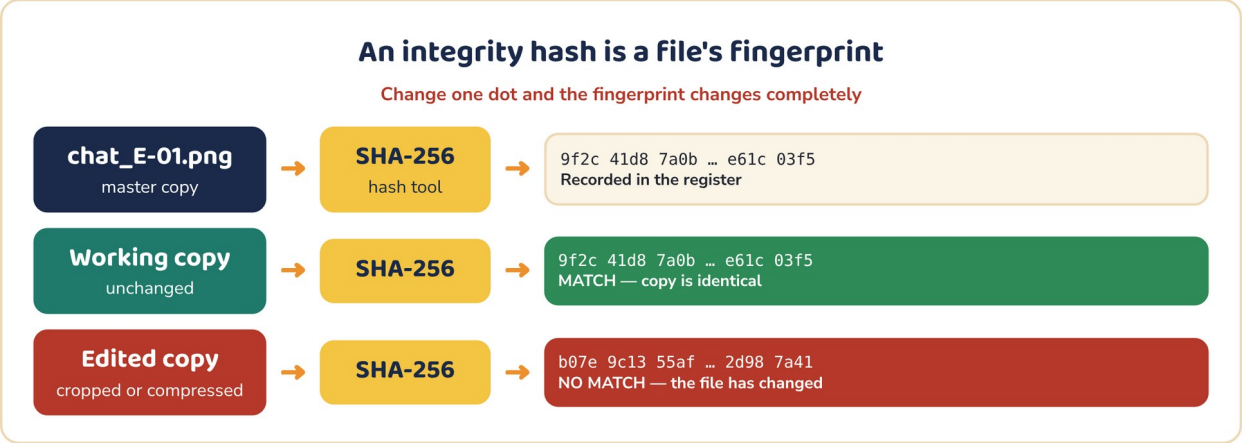


Figure 5.8 · An integrity hash is a file's fingerprint

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Device	How to compute SHA-256 (training files only)
Windows	Command Prompt: certutil -hashfile E-01.png SHA256 · or PowerShell: Get-FileHash E-01.png
macOS / Linux	Terminal: shasum -a 256 E-01.png (macOS) · sha256sum E-01.png (Linux)
Android / iPhone	A trusted hash-calculator app from the official store, approved by the programme

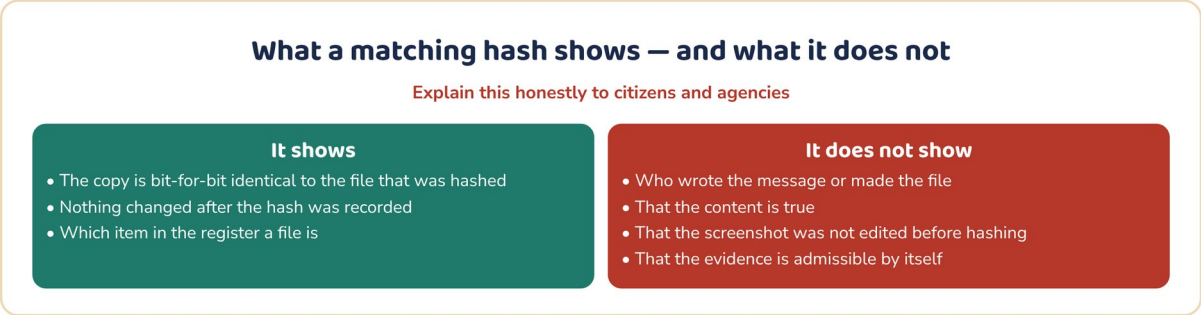


Figure 5.9 · What a matching hash shows — and what it does not

Remember

Hash the master once, record it, and never open the master for editing. Compare hashes whenever a copy changes hands.

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TOPIC 6 · SAFEGUARDING, THE LAW AND THE ROLE BOUNDARY

5 minutes · intimate and child-related material · POCSO s.19 · BSA 2023 ss. 61–63 · what the role does not do

What is it?

Some evidence is itself harmful. Copying or forwarding intimate images re-victimises the person, and possessing or sharing child sexual abuse material is a serious offence even when the intention is to help. For such material the First Responder preserves **only identifiers** — links, usernames, platform and time — and reports.

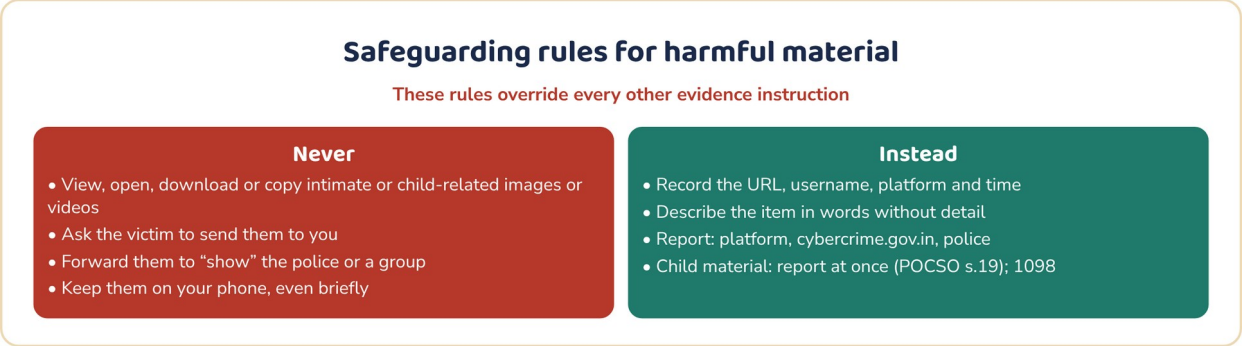


Figure 5.10 · Safeguarding rules for harmful material

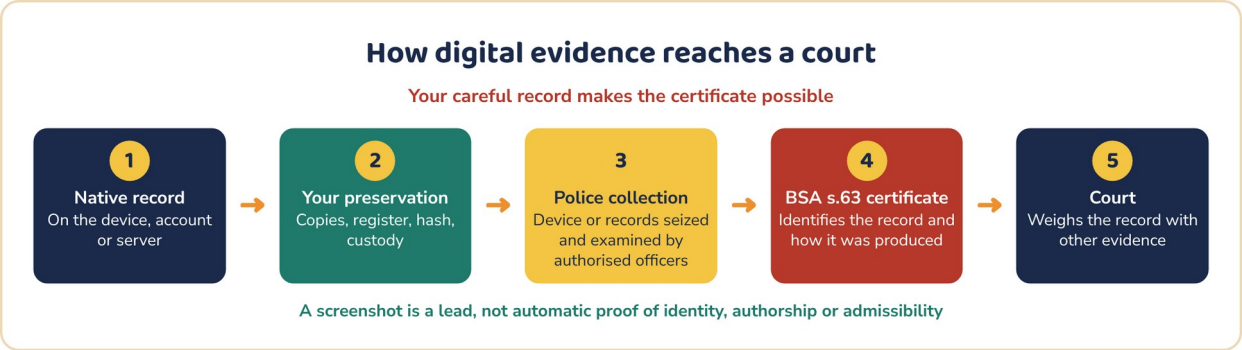


Figure 5.11 · How digital evidence reaches a court

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Law	What it says, in simple words
Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam 2023, s. 61	An electronic record cannot be refused as evidence merely because it is electronic
BSA 2023, ss. 62–63	The contents of an electronic record are proved in the prescribed way, usually with a certificate identifying the record and how it was produced
POCSO Act 2012, s. 19	Anyone who knows that a child is being sexually abused or exploited must report it to the police or the Special Juvenile Police Unit
IT Act 2000, s. 67B	Publishing, transmitting, browsing or storing child sexual material electronically is an offence

The preservation boundary

In the role: advise the citizen not to delete; capture working copies of what the citizen shows you, with consent; register, hash and hand over.

Outside the role: unlocking or taking the device, forensic imaging, recovering deleted data, accessing the suspect's accounts, analysing malware. Refer these to the police or the IT lead.

KEY TAKEAWAYS FROM MODULE 5

Takeaway	In one line
Minimum, complete, fast	Save what the agency needs to act, without delaying help
Original untouched	Work on copies; never delete, reset or uninstall
Three times, in IST	Event · capture · transfer
Register and receipt	Every item, every transfer, every signature
Hash shows sameness	Not authorship or truth
Links, not images	For intimate or child-related material — and report

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